

ELECTION 2009

Cover story

OPINION POLL

All things considered, which party do you think would be the best to solve the problems of the country?

	Cong	34
	BJP	27
	BSP	4
	CPI(M)	4
	SP	3

Other Parties: 26; Don't know/can't say: 2 (All figures in per cent)

Voters in many Congress-ruled states felt the BJP was better placed, an indication of early anti-incumbency.

same poll two years ago had given the "Third Front and others" a 25.9 per cent share of the votes and 115 seats. Though it notched up a 33.9 per cent vote share, the poll had pushed the NDA to its nadir with just 155 seats. Paradoxically, while the latest poll sees the NDA tally rising by between 20 and 30 seats even as its vote-share takes a 4 per cent knock, the UPA suffers losses of seats as well as vote-share, the latter dipping by as much as 5.9 per cent over 2007. On both counts, the gains belong to the Third Front and others, the positive swing in vote being a phenomenal 9.9 per cent. The poll also makes clear that the days of the uniform swing are over. The BJP lost heavily in the south and east, due to the BJP's desertion and the lack of an ally in crucial Tamil Nadu even as it made marginal gains in the north and the west. The UPA slipped in all four regions, with the negative swing ranging from 7.13 per cent in the south to 0.06 in the west. The significant swing in the Third Front's favour is due to impressive gains in the south and east which more than offset the marginal losses in the north and west.

The polls spring a few surprises and some very predictable results. For the first time in 11 years, Atal Bihari Vajpayee has yielded space to Manmohan Singh as the person most suited to be prime minister. In our February 2008

HEMANT CHAWLA



What is your opinion on India being run by a coalition government?

Good for India	Neither Good nor Bad	Bad
29	30	22

Don't know/can't say: 19 (All figures in per cent)

L.K. ADVANI WITH NDA ALLIES

